



FREE GUIDE

PSYCHOLOGICAL FIRST AID

When it hurts — here is step by step.

The 3 mistakes that prolong the pain after a breakup — and what to do instead.

WELCOME

This guide is your first aid kit for heartbreak

A breakup hurts like an injury — because that is exactly what it is. Neuroscience shows that romantic rejection activates the same brain regions as physical pain. You are not weak; you are wounded. And wounds heal faster when you stop reopening them.

What you will get from this guide

- 1 The 3 mistakes**
that silently keep the pain alive — and the science behind each one.
- 2 A first-aid toolkit**
six practical tools you can use the moment the wave hits.
- 3 A clear path forward**
the first 72 hours, plus a preview of the 21-day program.

The principle behind everything: Look, Listen, Link

Psychological first aid, the framework this guide is built on, rests on three actions used by aid workers worldwide: **Look** — notice what is happening; **Listen** — let your feelings speak without judging them; **Link** — reconnect with people and routines that hold you up. This guide takes you through all three.

What NOT to expect

- ☐ No promise that you will “get over it” in a week — recovery is not linear.
- ☐ No blaming — the goal is understanding, not guilt.
- ☐ No magic — only actions that research shows actually help.

THE 3 MISTAKES

Three habits that keep the wound open

After a loss, your brain does what it is designed to do: it tries to make sense of the pain. But three common strategies — repeating, checking, and suppressing — trick the brain into treating the pain as an active threat, again and again. Here is what they are, why they hurt, and what to do instead.

MISTAKE 1 · 01

The replay loop — reliving the story on repeat

- ☐ Replaying conversations and moments, asking “what if” and “why” for hours.
- ☐ Scrolling old messages and photos as if they were evidence to re-examine.
- ☐ Feeling drained after “thinking it through”, yet unable to stop.

Why it keeps hurting

Decades of research on response styles show that **rumination — repetitive negative thinking about the loss — prolongs distress** and predicts worse recovery months later. The problem is not thinking about the relationship; it is the way you think: looping, without new answers, while the brain stays in alarm mode. Studies find rumination is one of the strongest predictors of emotional difficulty after a breakup — more than the breakup itself.

What to do instead

- 1 Put grief in a container.**
Schedule one 20-minute “grief window” per day at the same time. Outside it, when the loop starts, say: “Not now — at 7 pm.” The thought still gets its turn; it just stops running your day.
- 2 Switch from “why” to “what”.**
“Why did this happen?” loops forever. “What did I learn, and what do I want now?” moves forward. Write one sentence of the second kind each day.
- 3 Do, don’t just think.**
Action interrupts the loop physically. A 10-minute walk, a task with your hands, a call to a friend — research on behavioral activation shows activity lifts mood where thinking alone cannot.

“Rumination feels like solving a problem. It is actually rehearsing a wound.”

MISTAKE 2 · 02

Digital surveillance — checking their life online

- ☐ Opening their profile “just once” — several times a day.
- ☐ Reading meaning into their posts, stories and online activity.
- ☐ Feeling worse after every check, but checking again within the hour.

Why it keeps hurting

A series of studies on ex-partner surveillance found that **monitoring a former partner on social media is linked to more distress, more jealousy, more longing, and less personal growth** — and the effect shows up the same day and even the next day. It is not “just curiosity”: every check reactivates the attachment system and resets the clock on recovery.

What to do instead

- 1 Create distance on purpose.**
Mute first (you can do it without unfriending). Then unfollow. Then, if the urge persists, block for 30 days. Distance is not cruelty — it is first aid.
- 2 Make checking cost something.**
Move the apps off your home screen; log out of accounts. When the urge appears, do the 90-second urge-surfing exercise (see toolkit) instead.
- 3 Feed the information vacuum.**
Your brain is scanning for news about them. Give it new input: one article, one podcast, one conversation with a real person — daily.

“Every check tells your brain: they still matter more than you do.”

MISTAKE 3 · 03

Suppression — being “fine” when you are not

- ☐ Telling yourself “I should be over this by now” and pushing feelings down.
- ☐ Staying busy non-stop so there is no quiet moment to feel.
- ☐ Smiling through it while the body carries tension, bad sleep, low energy.

Why it keeps hurting

The classic “white bear” experiments showed that **the more you try to suppress a thought, the more it returns** — a phenomenon called the ironic rebound. Emotion research adds that suppression increases physical arousal and intensifies the emotion afterwards, while **naming an emotion (affect labeling) calms the brain’s alarm center** within seconds. Feelings you allow pass; feelings you trap stay.

What to do instead

1 Name it to tame it.

Say precisely what you feel: “I feel rejected”, “I feel lost”, “I feel relief and guilt at the same time”. Labeling moves activity from the alarm system to the thinking brain.

2 Give the feeling a body.

Emotions live in the body. Sit with the feeling for 90 seconds, breathing slowly, and notice where it lives — chest, throat, stomach. It rises, peaks and falls — usually within a couple of minutes — when you stop feeding it with thoughts.

3 Speak it to one person.

Expressive writing and talking both help — but they must be real. Write a letter you will never send, then burn or delete it. Tell one trusted person the honest version, not the brave one.

“What you resist, persists. What you allow, passes.”

FIRST-AID TOOLKIT

Six tools for the moments it hits

Keep this page open on your phone. Each tool takes under two minutes. None of them erase the pain — they carry you through the worst of the wave, and that is enough.

1 • The 5-4-3-2-1 grounding

When panic or flooding thoughts arrive, anchor yourself in the room:

- ☐ 5 things you can see
- ☐ 4 things you can touch
- ☐ 3 things you can hear
- ☐ 2 things you can smell
- ☐ 1 thing you can taste

Count slowly, out loud if possible. It takes about 60 seconds.

2 • Box breathing

Breathe in for 4 counts, hold for 4, out for 4, hold for 4. Repeat 4–6 times.

- ☐ Inhale through the nose — 4 counts
- ☐ Hold — 4 counts
- ☐ Exhale slowly — 4 counts
- ☐ Hold — 4 counts

This slows the heart rate and tells the nervous system the danger has passed.

3 • Urge surfing

An urge — to check their profile, to text them, to look at photos — behaves like a wave: it rises, peaks, and falls within minutes.

- ☐ Notice the urge and name it: "This is an urge to check."
- ☐ Do not fight it and do not follow it. Watch it.
- ☐ Breathe and wait 90 seconds. The wave peaks and breaks.

You are not resisting the urge; you are riding it. The craving loses power every time you do.

4 · Name it to tame it

Use precise emotion words. "I feel bad" keeps the brain vague; "I feel ashamed" and "I feel lonely" give it something real to process.

- ☐ Pause and scan: what exactly am I feeling right now?
- ☐ Pick the most precise word you can.
- ☐ Say it silently: "This is grief", "This is anger", "This is fear".

Studies show labeling an emotion calms the amygdala — the brain's alarm — within seconds.

5 · The grief container

Schedule your pain instead of letting it schedule you.

- ☐ Choose a fixed 20-minute window each day (e.g. 7:00 pm).
- ☐ During the day, postpone rumination: "Not now — at 7 pm."
- ☐ In the window, let everything out: think, write, cry if needed. When it ends, close the container.

The feeling is honoured, not suppressed — it just gets a boundary.

6 · The 30-day digital boundary

A complete break from their digital footprint, for one month.

- ☐ Mute or unfollow everywhere. No exceptions for "just checking stories".
- ☐ Log out of accounts you open reflexively.
- ☐ If you break the boundary, do not punish yourself — restart the 30 days and move on.

Research links ex-partner surveillance to slower recovery. One month of distance is the single most effective tool in this guide.

THE 21-DAY PROGRAM

From first aid to recovery — one email per day

This guide stops the bleeding. The 21-day program rebuilds. One short email each morning walks you through the three phases below — with a daily action that takes 10–15 minutes.

Week 1 — Stabilize

Feelings, sleep, food, routine. You learn to carry the pain instead of fighting it.

- Daily grief container
- Sleep & routine basics
- Emotion labeling practice

Week 2 — Rebuild

Identity, friendships, activities. You rediscover who you are outside the relationship.

- Values & identity work
- Reconnecting with people
- New activities, small doses

Week 3 — Look forward

Meaning, goals, growth. You turn the loss into a story that carries you forward.

- What this taught me
- Concrete goals for 90 days
- A letter to future me

The first 72 hours — your immediate protocol



Hour 0–24:

Feel everything, decide nothing. Tell one trusted person. Eat, hydrate, sleep. No big decisions, no contact with them.



Day 2:

Name the top three emotions with precise words. Mute/unfollow everywhere. Set your grief window time.



Day 3:

Take one physical action — a walk, a workout, a task you have postponed. Write the letter you will not send. Book a coffee with a friend.

YOU MATTER

When to reach for professional help

This guide is educational first aid, not therapy. Please contact a professional if you:

- ☐ Feel unable to function — work, eating, or basic care are falling apart for more than two weeks.
- ☐ Have thoughts of self-harm or suicide — this is an emergency. Reach out now.
- ☐ Use alcohol, substances, or risky behaviour to numb the pain.
- ☐ Feel stuck in anger or despair that does not lift with time and support.

Immediate help (EU)

- **Emergency services: 112 (any EU country)**
- **Emotional support helplines: 116 123 (free in many EU countries)**
- **Search “crisis helpline” + your country for local 24/7 support**

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Built on research

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- Wegner, D. M. (1994). Ironical processes of mental control (the “white bear” effect).
- Gross, J. J. (2002). Emotion regulation: affective, cognitive, and social consequences.
- Lieberman, M. D. et al. (2007). Putting feelings into words: affect labeling.
- Marshall, T. C. (2012). Facebook surveillance of former romantic partners: associations with post-breakup recovery and personal growth.
- Pennebaker, J. W. (1997). Opening Up: The Healing Power of Expressing Emotions.
- Neff, K. D. (2011). Self-Compassion: The Proven Power of Being Kind to Yourself.
- World Health Organization (2011). Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers.

This guide summarises established findings for educational purposes. Individual results vary; when in doubt, seek professional support.

First aid today. A path forward tomorrow.

When you are ready for the next step, the 21-day program delivers one small, science-backed action to you

innerfirstaid.com

and is not a substitute for professional psychological, medical or therapeutic advice, diagnosis or treatment. If you are in crisis, contact emergency services.